

MySQL-Oracle comparison chart

Benefits of MySQL:

- Price
- Open source (no lock-in)
- More than one development entity (also at askmonty.org, ourdelta, etc)
- Much easier to deploy
- Bigger employment base, well known
- Easy to set up replication
- De-facto standard in the Internet world
- Pluggable storage engines, which makes MySQL suitable for a wide range of applications that would not be possible with a conventional design.

Benefits of Oracle:

- More complete database (a lot of features)
- Scales better on large systems
- Trusted by the big enterprise users who still have doubts about open source.

—courtesy Monty

get things going without having to pay a lot (of time or money) to get the database running.”

All this is from the point of view of the MySQL founders. No one really knows what those at Oracle are thinking. There's been no word about MySQL's future in Oracle's statements. There are several possibilities, which may determine what Oracle could do with MySQL [see the side box on this page].

If Oracle does put MySQL in the 'benefit' category, it's good news. Oracle is a profit-driven, high-speed train, and can achieve what Sun couldn't—monetise MySQL. This will happen only if the company sees some benefit from MySQL. Given the installation base MySQL has, there is no doubt Oracle will get access to that market. Also, it will now have the entire developer base working around MySQL. Monty points out the benefits Oracle will get by merely owning the MySQL brand: "Owning the trademark of the most used open source client server database gives a lot of value. Oracle can use the MySQL website to spread their message."

But will the core developers return to their much loved project and join Oracle? "We would be happy to cooperate very closely with Oracle but we are not likely to join. After working for a big company like Sun, we enjoy the extra freedom and benefits we get in a smaller company.

What will Oracle do with MySQL?

There are several possibilities around what Oracle can do with MySQL. Let's see what the MySQL founders think of these possibilities. Both Axmark and Monty have shared their opinions about the possible scenarios:

- (a) Kill it by stopping development or slowing it down, thus rendering it useless.
Axmark: Meaningless, since there already are a few full/partial forks out there.
Monty: The reason for doing this is to stop MySQL from cannibalising on Oracle business.
- (b) Keep an inferior version open but make a polished version paid and closed.
Axmark: I doubt that would really work [make money] in my view.
Monty: The reason for this might be the same as I'd suggested for (a) but they may try to commercialise our current users to get some money back from their investment. This would cause even more people to want to fork MySQL.
- (c) Boost development, fix issues and create an excellent product to compete in the domain.
Axmark: I could see them making MySQL work very, very well on Windows to compete with Microsoft's database products. And still work well on Linux, but not aim so much for high-end transaction loads.
Monty: The reason for doing this would be to use MySQL to hurt the other commercial databases and gain market cap.
- (d) Sell it off.
Axmark: Probably not... since the ones who would pay well would directly compete with Oracle.
Monty: This could happen because they bought Sun for reasons other than MySQL and they don't find MySQL important; or if they have to do this because of US anti-trust laws.

Monty's fifth possibility: I would prefer to see an (e) happen where Oracle would promise to keep MySQL always free—and to ensure this freedom it would establish an independent entity to develop MySQL source code and work with the community.

Another thing is that I don't think Oracle can match the benefits of the hacking business model we have been using. The main problem is that the critical people needed to drive the MySQL project may not be staying around to give Oracle a chance to improve. I see it as my main job to ensure that the developer community is not split up and we keep the core engineers working on MySQL. If Oracle plays nice with these people, then things will improve dramatically with MySQL development," notes Monty.

So that's back to Square One! Everything will depend on what Oracle does with MySQL. In a scenario like this, MySQL users must be sweating over concerns about the future of a product their businesses depend on.

However, this is where the beauty of open source comes into the picture. No one owns the project, but only the brand. "The whole idea with FLOSS software is that it doesn't matter who owns it even remotely as much as it does for closed-

source software. So they [customers and users] can continue to use MySQL whatever happens. And there are still tons of good MySQL support people at Sun, so there is no problem buying support from Sun," says Axmark.

And just in case Oracle doesn't play nice, you can always fork the project. "With the current licence, there is no problem to fork. There are already several existing forks," says Monty. "The newest 'branch' is MariaDB that I am working on. We already have many of the core MySQL developers working on this so we have the competence to do this properly."

However, many feel that though forking might be easy, maintaining the fork and ensuring its popularity is the biggest challenge. Also, a customer might be wary of going for an unknown project instead of a well-known one. So, how can a fork be successful? Monty argues, "The brand popularity gives some protection for Oracle, but it has